

Contact Rules and Penalties as Strategy

Why the same grab costs five yards before the throw and forty after it, why linemen hold, and how a yellow flag rewrites a series

Third-and-9, a minute left in the half. The quarterback takes a deep drop and heaves the ball 45 yards down the left sideline toward a receiver who is not open. The cornerback is with him stride for stride, the ball comes down a yard out of reach, and the crowd groans. Then a yellow flag lands on the grass. The corner had grabbed the receiver's arm a split second before the ball arrived. Pass interference: first down, at the spot of the foul. A throw that was going nowhere has just gained 41 yards, and the rules analyst in the booth says the offense "knew exactly what it was doing." Two questions hide in that sentence. Why would a coach call a throw he expects to be incomplete? And why is the same grab worth five yards if it happens one second earlier, before the ball is in the air? This chapter reads the rule book the way coaches do: as a list of prices.

You'll be able to...

- Say where a defender may touch a receiver and when (the five-yard zone, then hands off until the throw, then the pass-interference rules) and name the foul for each kind of contact.
- Explain why defensive pass interference is a spot foul in the NFL and a 15-yard foul in college, and why that one difference makes NFL offenses throw deep into tight coverage.
- Tell a legal rub from an illegal pick by where the contact happens, and explain what holding, hands to the face, blocks in the back, cut blocks and chop blocks cost.
- Explain the player-safety rules (roughing the passer, the sliding quarterback, the defenseless player, the 2018 helmet rule, the horse-collar and hip-drop bans, the 2026 three-strike policy) and why each was written.
- Enforce a flag yourself: accept or decline, from which spot, how far (including half the distance), and what down it is next. Then call the foul before the referee announces it.
- Read a chart of penalty rates and say how a flag enters expected points (EPA).

You'll need

This chapter leans on a few earlier ones. One line each:

- **Press and the five-yard rule** (Coverage Fundamentals): a press corner lines up in the receiver's face to jam him at the snap; defenders may touch receivers only in the first five yards, a limit dating to the 1978 "Mel Blount rule." Man coverage gives each defender a receiver; zone coverage gives each an area.
- **Pass protection** (Pass Protection): five linemen (and sometimes backs and tight ends) block four or more rushers so the quarterback can throw from the pocket, the protected area behind the line. A sack is the quarterback tackled behind the line.
- **The one-yard rule for linemen** (Run-Pass Options): on a pass, an ineligible lineman may not be more than a yard downfield before the ball is thrown, the foul called illegal man downfield. It is why NFL RPOs look the way they do.
- **Rub routes** (Dropback Concepts): a rub route (also pick route) crosses receivers so a defender chasing one runs into traffic.
- **Cut blocks** (Zone Running): a cut block is a block at a defender's thighs or below, from the front, to put him on the ground.
- **Pre-snap fouls** (The Pre-Snap Phase): a false start or encroachment stops the play before it starts; offside lets it run. A foul that lets the play run is a *live-ball foul*, and the ball's spot before the snap is the *previous spot*.
- **Expected points** (Downs, Distance, and Field Position): expected points price a down, distance and yard line; EPA is the change in that price over one play. The line to gain is "the sticks."

Reading the diagrams: offense is blue circles (X, Y, Z, H receivers; Q quarterback; R running back; C center; unlabelled circles are linemen). Defense is outlined squares (C a cornerback, \$ the nickel back, FS the free safety, E and T linemen, M and W linebackers). Players with a **green ring** are the ones to watch. The darker blue line is the line of scrimmage and the faint lines are 5 yards apart. In this chapter a **star** marks a moment of contact (green: legal; red: a foul) and a yellow **flag** marks where an official would throw one.

The rule book as a price list

Every sport has rules about contact. Football has more of them than most, because almost every player on almost every snap is allowed to hit somebody. The rules don't try to stop contact. They decide **who may touch whom, where, and when**, and they attach a price to each violation: five yards, ten, fifteen, a first down, the spot of the foul, a safety, an ejection.

Prices change behaviour. A cornerback who knows that grabbing a receiver costs five yards will grab him on third-and-20, when five yards don't matter, and won't on third-and-2, when they decide the series. An offensive lineman beaten by a pass rusher will often hold rather than let his quarterback be sacked, because ten yards cost less than a sack plus the chance of a fumble. A play-caller who knows that pass interference is enforced at the spot will throw deep into coverage, because the flag is one of the throw's possible outcomes. None of this is cheating; it's arithmetic. Coaches teach it, and the NFL's competition committee, which proposes the rule changes the owners vote on each spring, adjusts the prices when it doesn't like how teams respond.

This chapter takes the rules in four groups:

1. **Contact on receivers**, the rules that shape pass coverage and route design: illegal contact, defensive holding, and pass interference in both directions.
2. **Blocking rules**, which shape what linemen and receivers may do: holding, hands to the face, blocks in the back, cut and chop blocks, and the lineman's one-yard limit on passes.
3. **Player-safety rules**, mostly written in the last twenty years to protect heads, knees and quarterbacks.
4. **Enforcement**, the mechanics that turn a flag into a new down and distance: accepting and declining, free plays, where the yards are walked off, and half the distance.

Then we price them with data: how often each foul is called, and what it does to expected points. (Officials, replay review and the rules of the ball itself, what counts as a catch or a fumble, are the next chapter, Officiating, Replay, and the Rules of the Ball.)

! Why it exists

Football's contact rules exist to keep two contests fair at once. One is between the offense and the defense: without limits, defenders would tackle receivers before every pass and linemen would tackle pass rushers, and the passing game would die. The other is between the players and the damage they can do to each other. Most rule changes of the last half-century have pushed one or both of those two ways: toward offense (1978, 2004) and toward safety (2005 onward). Read any rule change by asking which contest it was protecting.

The receiver's first five yards: illegal contact and defensive holding

A pass play is a race. The receiver needs to reach a spot on the field at a set time, and the quarterback needs to throw it there before the rush arrives. A defender's best weapon in that race is his hands: knock the receiver off his line, slow him, turn him, and the timing of the whole play breaks. The NFL rules allow exactly a little of that.

Here are the rules, as the NFL writes them for 2026:¹

- **Within five yards of the line of scrimmage**, a defender may *chuck* (jam, push, re-route) a receiver who is in front of him. That is what a press corner is doing at the snap.
- **Beyond five yards**, while the quarterback is still in the pocket with the ball, a defender may not initiate contact with the receiver. He may use his hands only to protect himself, and contact that started inside the five yards has to end as the two of them leave the zone: he may not shove, hook or ride him past it. The foul is **illegal contact: five yards and an automatic first down**.
- **Anywhere on the field**, before the pass is thrown, a defender may not grab, hook or tackle a receiver, or otherwise restrict him: **defensive holding**, also **five yards and an automatic first down**. Holding can happen inside the five yards too. A jam with open hands is legal; a fistful of jersey is not.
- **Once the ball is thrown**, both of those rules hand over to the pass-interference rules, below.

¹NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules of the National Football League*, Rule 8, Section 4 ("Legal and Illegal Contact With Eligible Receivers"): within five yards of the line of scrimmage a defender may chuck an eligible receiver in front of him; beyond that zone, while the player who received the snap remains in the pocket with the ball, a defender may not initiate contact with a receiver and must release one he has been in contact with as they exit the zone (illegal contact: five yards and an automatic first down); the restriction ends when the passer leaves the pocket or the ball is thrown. Defensive holding; Rule 8, Section 4, Article 6 and Rule 12, Section 1, Article 6 (five yards and an automatic first down; still in force when the passer leaves the pocket). <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. A plain-language summary of each foul with video is in NFL Football Operations' video rulebook: <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-video-rulebook/>

- The illegal-contact restriction lifts when the quarterback **leaves the pocket**, so on a scramble a defender may chuck a receiver beyond five yards. Holding is still holding, and once the ball is in the air pass interference applies again.

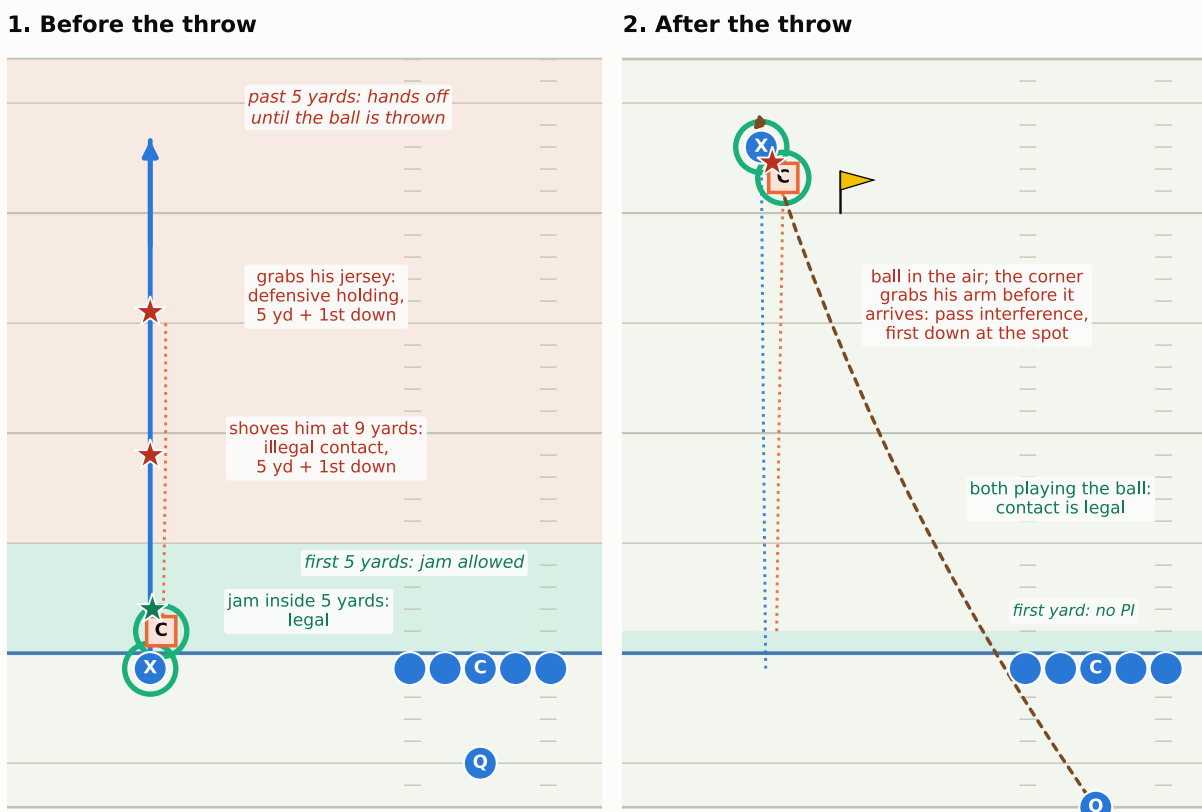


Figure 1: The receiver's rules by depth and by moment, on one go route. Left, before the throw: inside the first five yards (green) the corner (C) may jam X; past five yards, while the quarterback is in the pocket with the ball, contact that impedes him is illegal contact, and grabbing or restricting him anywhere is defensive holding. Both cost five yards and an automatic first down. Right, after the throw: the pass-interference rules take over. Contact more than a yard past the line that significantly hinders the receiver's chance to catch a catchable ball is defensive pass interference, enforced at the spot. Two players both playing the ball may collide legally.

Two prices, five yards and a first down, look small next to pass interference, and they are meant to. The automatic first down is the expensive part. On first-and-10 a five-yard foul gives the offense first-and-5, a nice gain. On third-and-12 it erases the down: the defense had the offense behind the sticks and needed one stop, and now it starts the series over. (The numbers on this, down by down, are in What penalties cost, below.)

Why five yards? A short history

The five-yard zone is a compromise struck in 1978. Until the mid-1970s a defender could hit a receiver repeatedly all the way down the field until the ball was thrown, and teams built defenses on it. The league chipped at that in 1974 and 1977, then in 1978 limited contact to the first five yards, the change still called the "Mel Blount rule" after the Steelers' 6-foot-3 cornerback who had been mauling receivers. The same 1978 package let offensive linemen extend their arms and open their hands in pass protection.² Both halves of that package pointed the same way, toward passing, and the long rise of the NFL passing game starts there (The 1978 Liberation tells that story).

²Pro Football Hall of Fame, NFL history, 1978: "Rules changes permitted a defender to maintain contact with a receiver within five yards of the line of scrimmage, but restricted contact beyond that point," and offensive linemen were allowed to extend their arms and open their hands in pass blocking: <https://www.profootballhof.com/football-history/football-history/1960-1979/1978> . On the name and Blount's own account, Steelers Depot, "Mel Blount explains play that created Mel Blount rule" (Feb. 2024): <https://steelersdepot.com/2024/02/mel-blount-explains-play-that-created-mel-blount-rule> . The 1974 step (one chuck allowed once a receiver is three yards downfield) and the 1977 step (no second contact after a jam): *Boston Globe*, "How wide receivers have evolved in the NFL" (Sept. 4, 2013): <https://www.bostonglobe.com/sports/2013/09/04/how-wide-receivers-have-evolved-nfl/akAnTGNJaS7OrVnjAbbN6J/story.html>

The rule was then on the books for 25 years without being enforced very hard. Defensive backs learned what officials would tolerate (a hand on the hip at eight yards, a tug at the top of the route), and by the early 2000s the best press teams were playing the 1977 game with 1978 rules. The next film room is the game that ended that.

i Film room: Patriots vs. Colts, 2003 AFC Championship (Jan. 18, 2004)

In the AFC Championship Game after the 2003 season, Bill Belichick's Patriots beat Peyton Manning's Colts 24–14 in Foxborough. Manning, that season's co-MVP, threw four interceptions, three of them to cornerback Ty Law.³ On the film, New England's defensive backs jam, ride and bump Indianapolis's receivers well past five yards, all game, and few flags fly.

The Colts' president, Bill Polian, sat on the competition committee. That off-season the committee made illegal contact and defensive holding beyond five yards a "point of emphasis": officials were told to call the rule as written. Patriots fans call it the "Ty Law rule." The flags came at once: by one count illegal-contact fouls rose from 79 in the 2003 regular season to 191 in 2004 (nflverse's play-by-play, which records only one foul per play, has 49 and 123), and teams averaged about 225 passing yards a game in 2004, up from 214.⁴ Manning threw 49 touchdown passes in 2004, breaking Dan Marino's single-season record.⁵

What to notice: the rule didn't change; its price did. A rule that is called is a different rule from one that isn't, which is why "points of emphasis" announced each summer are worth reading. On a broadcast, watch a press corner's hands after the receiver's fifth step. If they stay on him, the next flag is coming.

What the five-yard zone does to schemes

- **Press is about the release.** All of the corner's legal contact has to happen in the first five yards, about the first second of the route. If the receiver gets through clean, he is in open space with a defender chasing him. That's why pressed corners nearly always have a safety behind them, and why on third-and-long many defenses don't press at all (Coverage Fundamentals).
- **Offenses build releases that dodge the jam.** Stacked and bunched receivers (one behind another, so the defender can't get hands on the back one), motion to get a running start, and quick throws that are out before five yards matter.
- **Zone defenders have to pass receivers off, not re-route them.** A linebacker in a hook zone may not shove a crossing receiver at eight yards, so zone defense is about positioning, not collision. The jam that survives is the Cover 2 corner's, which happens inside the five yards (Cover 2 and Tampa 2).
- **A scramble changes the rules.** When the quarterback leaves the pocket, defenders may chuck receivers downfield again. Part of why the scramble drill (Quarterback Play) is hard to defend is that coverage gets messy; part of why it is not easier is that defenders get their hands back.
- **Smart fouls.** A corner beaten off the line on a go route can grab the receiver before the throw and give up five yards and a first down rather than a touchdown. Nobody coaches it out loud, but everybody knows the price.

Pass interference, both ways

Once the ball is thrown, the question changes from "may he touch the receiver?" to "is he playing the ball?" **Defensive pass interference (DPI)** is contact by a defender, after the ball is thrown and more than one yard past the line of scrimmage, that **significantly hinders** an eligible receiver's chance to catch the ball. The rule lists the usual acts: grabbing an arm or the jersey, cutting in front of the receiver without looking for the ball, hooking him, putting an arm across his body, tackling him early. And it lists what is *not* interference:⁶

³Pro Football Reference, "AFC Championship - Indianapolis Colts at New England Patriots - January 18th, 2004" (Patriots 24, Colts 14; Manning 4 interceptions): <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/boxscores/200401180nwe.htm>; "2003–04 NFL playoffs," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2003%E2%80%9304_NFL_playoffs. Manning and Steve McNair shared the 2003 AP MVP award. Law's three interceptions: *Boston Globe*, "Picking off a few of Ty Law's finest moments" (Aug. 1, 2019): <https://www.bostonglobe.com/sports/patriots/2019/08/01/picking-off-few-law-finest-moments/IdEhXtf0YSgE1jbJYTPdmK/story.html>

⁴Tom E. Curran / NBC Sports Boston, "They called it the 'Ty Law Rule' ... and that was OK with him" (Aug. 3, 2019): <https://www.nbcsportsboston.com/nfl/new-england-patriots/they-called-it-the-ty-law-rule-and-that-was-ok-with-him/393549/> (Polian, a member of the competition committee, and his complaints after the January 2004 AFC Championship Game; the 2004 emphasis on downfield contact). The 79-to-191 count: Mike Florio, ProFootballTalk, "New point of emphasis results in plenty of flags for illegal contact, defensive holding" (Aug. 8, 2014): <https://www.nbcsports.com/nfl/profootballtalk/rumor-mill/news/new-point-of-emphasis-results-in-plenty-of-flags-for-illegal-contact-defensive-holding>. Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, regular seasons: plays whose main foul is "Illegal Contact," 49 in 2003 and 123 in 2004; passing yards per team game 213.9 in 2003 and 225.3 in 2004.

⁵Pro Football Reference, Peyton Manning: 49 touchdown passes in 2004, then the single-season record (Dan Marino had 48 in 1984): <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/players/M/MannPe00.htm>

⁶NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 8, Section 5 (pass interference): "any act by a player more than one yard beyond the line of scrimmage [that] significantly hinders an eligible player's opportunity to catch the ball"; the defense's restrictions begin when the ball is thrown and the offense's at the snap, both ending when the ball is touched; the rule lists acts that are and are not pass interference, including contact on a pass that is clearly uncatchable and incidental contact when both players are playing the ball. <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. Offensive pass interference,

- contact when both players are making a genuine attempt to catch or bat the ball;
- incidental contact, such as feet tangling, that doesn't materially affect the receiver;
- contact on a pass that is **clearly uncatchable**;
- contact before the throw, which is illegal contact or holding instead (five yards), not DPI.

Offensive pass interference (OPI) is the mirror image, with one big difference: the offense's restrictions start at the **snap**, not the throw. From the snap until the pass is touched, an offensive player more than a yard past the line may not initiate contact that hinders a defender. The two everyday versions are the **push-off** (a receiver extends his arm to create separation at the top of a route or at the catch point) and the **illegal pick** (a receiver blocks a defender downfield before the ball is thrown, to free a teammate). OPI costs **ten yards from the previous spot**, and the down is replayed.

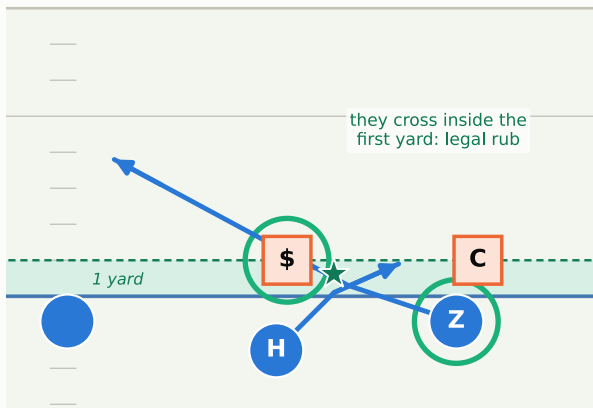
🔥 Common misconception

"He grabbed the receiver, so it's pass interference." Only if the ball was in the air. The same grab a second before the throw is defensive holding (five yards and a first down); a hard shove at eight yards before the throw is illegal contact (same price). The difference matters enormously, because DPI is enforced at the spot. When a flag flies on a pass, look at whether the ball had left the quarterback's hand at the moment of the foul, and you'll know which of the three it is.

The one-yard strip: when a pick is legal

Pass interference by either side can only happen **more than one yard past the line of scrimmage**. Inside that first yard, contact between a receiver and a defender is not interference. That one-yard strip is why rub routes are legal at all. A receiver may release into a defender who is covering a teammate, and if the bump happens within a yard of the line, there is no foul. If the same receiver runs three yards downfield, stops, and plants himself in the defender's path, it is OPI.

Legal: contact inside 1 yard



Foul: a block 3 yards downfield

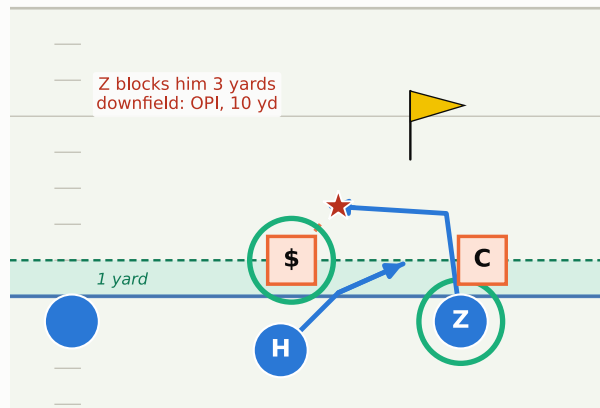


Figure 2: Pick-play legality is measured in one yard. Slot H runs a quick out; outside receiver Z releases inside on a slant, across the path of the nickel (\$) who is pressing H in man coverage. Left: the two cross within a yard of the line (the green strip), so the bump is legal. The nickel has to fight through it and H is open in the flat. Right: Z runs three yards upfield first and then steps into the nickel's path before the ball is thrown: offensive pass interference, ten yards from the previous spot. The same concept, a yard and a half apart.

The difference is often inches and intent, judged at full speed, so officials watch for the giveaway signs of a block: a receiver who stops running his route, turns his shoulders to the defender, or extends his arms. Offenses coach the opposite: run *through* the defender's path, keep running the route, and make the contact happen at the line, where it's legal. That's why so many rubs come from **stacks** and **bunches**, formations where receivers start close together and their paths cross in the first step or two (Spread Formations).

Defenses answer in three ways. They play **zone** against bunches, because a zone defender isn't chasing anyone through traffic. They **switch** (or *banjo*) in man coverage, trading receivers by agreement so nobody has to chase through the cross (Man Coverage).

ten yards from the previous spot: NFL video rulebook, "Offensive Pass Interference": <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-video-rulebook/offensive-pass-interference>

And they **align deeper**: a defender who lines up four or five yards off the ball can't be picked inside the first yard, because he's not there yet. Every one of those answers exists because of the one-yard strip.

The spot foul: why DPI is football's most expensive flag

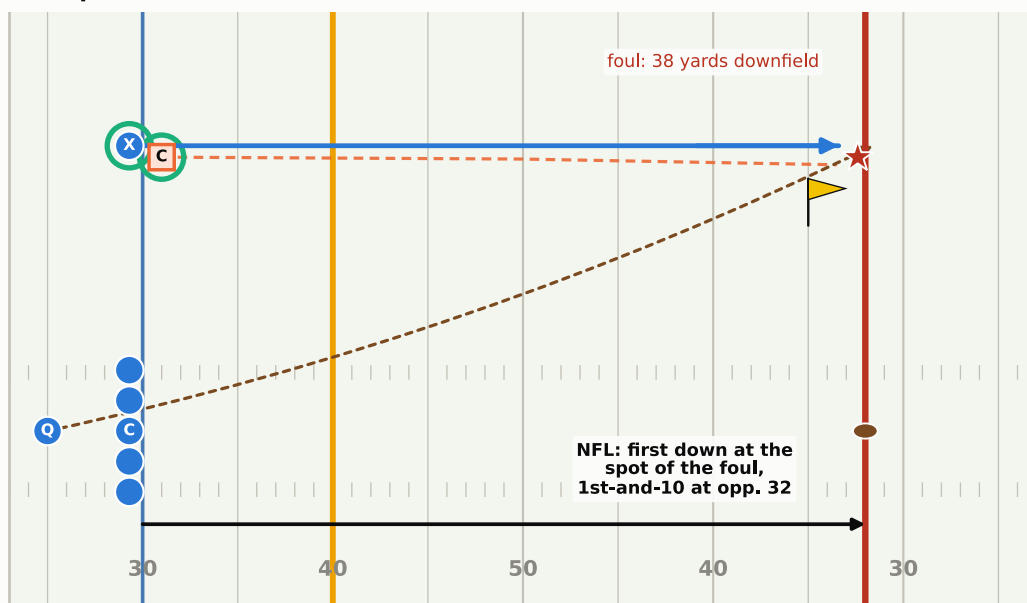
Most fouls are enforced from the **previous spot**, where the ball was snapped. Defensive pass interference is different. In the NFL it is a **spot foul**: the offense gets an automatic first down **at the spot where the foul happened**, however far downfield that is. A foul 40 yards past the line is a 40-yard penalty. If the foul happens in the end zone, the ball goes to the **1-yard line**, first and goal.⁷

College football does it differently. Under the NCAA rule, defensive pass interference is **15 yards from the previous spot** and an automatic first down; only when the foul happens less than 15 yards downfield is it enforced at the spot.⁸ The high-school rule is also 15 yards. The NFL is the outlier, and it is the reason the most consequential judgment call in football carries no cap.

⁷NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 8, Section 5, penalty provisions: defensive pass interference is a first down at the spot of the foul; if the foul occurs in the end zone, first down on the 1-yard line (or halfway to the goal line if the previous spot was inside the 2). <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. See also "Pass interference," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pass_interference

⁸NCAA, *Football Rules and Interpretations*, Rule 7, Section 3 (pass interference): defensive pass interference is 15 yards from the previous spot and an automatic first down, or at the spot of the foul if it is less than 15 yards beyond the previous spot; unchanged for 2026 ("defensive pass interference will remain a spot foul, with a maximum of a 15-yard penalty," National Football Foundation rules summary, reported in the *Altoona Mirror*, Aug. 11, 2026: <https://www.altoonamirror.com/sports/psu/2026/08/cfb-nff-rules-targeting-penalty-changing/>). "Pass interference," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pass_interference. High school (NFHS): 15 yards from the previous spot, without an automatic first down since 2013: *The Columbian*, "Prep football primer: Rule changes for 2013 season": <https://blogs.columbian.com/high-school-sports/2013/09/06/prep-football-primer-rule-changes-2013-season>

NFL: spot foul



College and high school: 15-yard cap

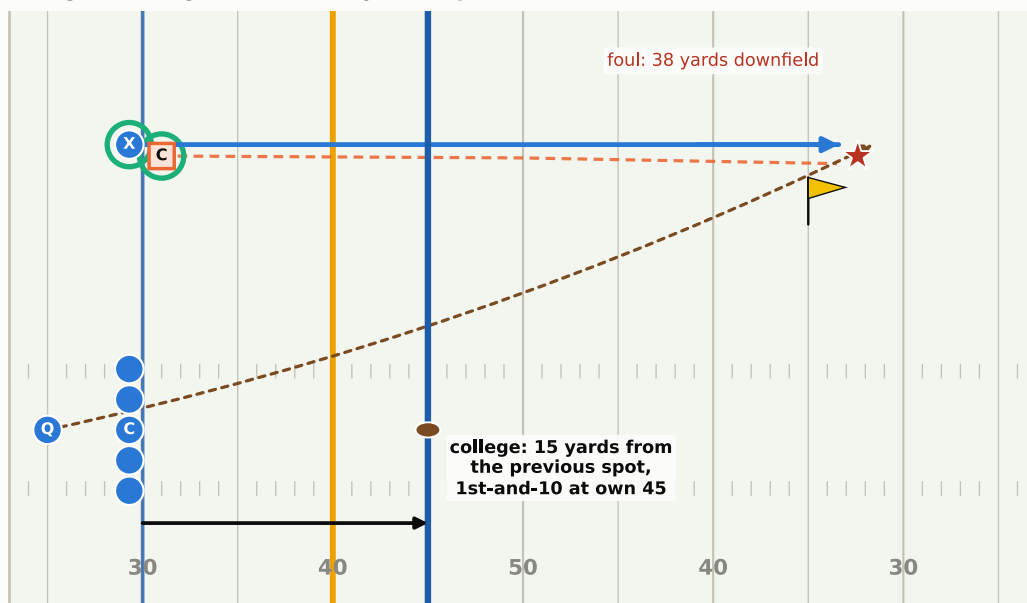


Figure 3: One foul, two rulebooks. Second-and-10 from the offense's own 30 (offense moving right). X runs a go route, the ball is thrown deep, and the corner (C) grabs him at the catch point, 38 yards downfield, at the opponent's 32. Top, NFL: a spot foul, so it is first-and-10 at the opponent's 32, a 38-yard penalty. Bottom, college: 15 yards from the previous spot and an automatic first down, so first-and-10 at the offense's own 45. The same grab is worth 23 more yards in the NFL.

! Why it exists: the spot foul

What it solves. The NFL's logic is that a penalty should give back what the foul took away. A defender beaten deep who tackles the receiver before the ball arrives has prevented, quite possibly, a 40-yard completion. Cap the penalty at 15 yards and every beaten defender would happily pay it. With no cap, there's nothing to gain by tackling a receiver who has beaten you; you have to play the ball.

What it costs. The penalty is huge and the call is a judgment. "Significantly hinders" is decided at full speed by an official who may be 20 yards away, and the difference between a legal, hand-fighting 50-50 ball and a 45-yard flag is sometimes a single tug. That combination makes DPI the call most likely to decide a game, and it is why fans and coaches keep proposing either the college cap or replay review for it. (The NFL tried replay once; see the film room below.)

What the spot foul does to offenses: throw deep, into coverage

Put the two rules together and an NFL offense has a reason to throw deep that a college offense doesn't. Each deep pass has four kinds of outcome: a completion, an incompleteness, an interception, and a defensive pass interference flag, which is, in effect, a long completion that also stops the clock. In the 2021–2025 regular seasons, throws travelling 15 or more yards in the air drew a DPI flag about 4.1 times per 100 throws, against about 0.9 for shorter ones, and those deep flags averaged 23 yards. Counting them in raises the expected points of an average deep throw from +0.38 to +0.45 per attempt.⁹

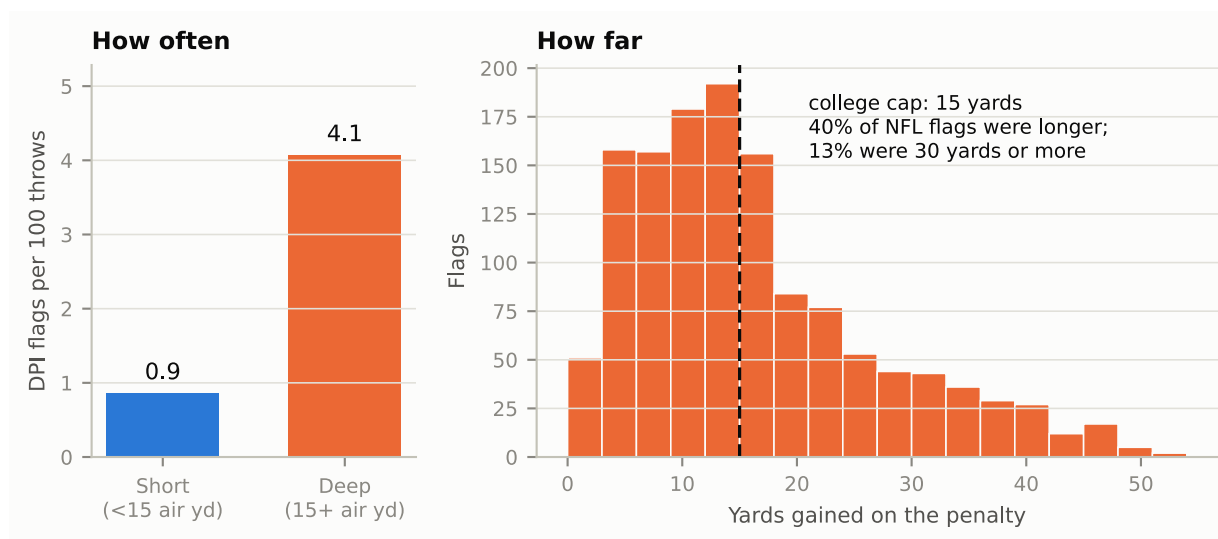


Figure 4: Why NFL offenses throw deep into tight coverage. Left: defensive pass interference flags per 100 throws, short (under 15 air yards) and deep (15 or more), 2021–2025 regular seasons; a deep throw is several times as likely to draw one. Right: how long each accepted DPI was. The dashed line is the college cap of 15 yards; every flag to its right would have been worth less under college rules. Source: nflverse play-by-play, accepted DPI flags on scrimmage downs.

That's why you see things that look like bad decisions: a quarterback throwing up a 50-50 ball to a receiver who is covered, or a back-shoulder throw into a corner who has his back turned. Two of the outcomes (a catch or a flag) are big gains, one (an incompleteness) costs a down, and only the interception is a disaster. Big, physical receivers are worth more in the NFL partly because they win those balls or draw the flag, and defensive backs are taught to turn and find the ball, because a defender who never looks back isn't "playing the ball" and any contact gets flagged (Man Coverage).

Here is that play, moving. Watch the corner's hand at the end.

⁹Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, 2021–2025 regular seasons. Throws: pass attempts (sacks excluded) with a recorded `pass_length`, deep meaning 15 or more air yards. DPI flags: accepted "Defensive Pass Interference" on scrimmage downs, classified short or deep from the play description ("pass incomplete deep left..."). The EPA comparison averages deep throws alone, then deep throws plus the deep DPI snaps that the flags wiped out.

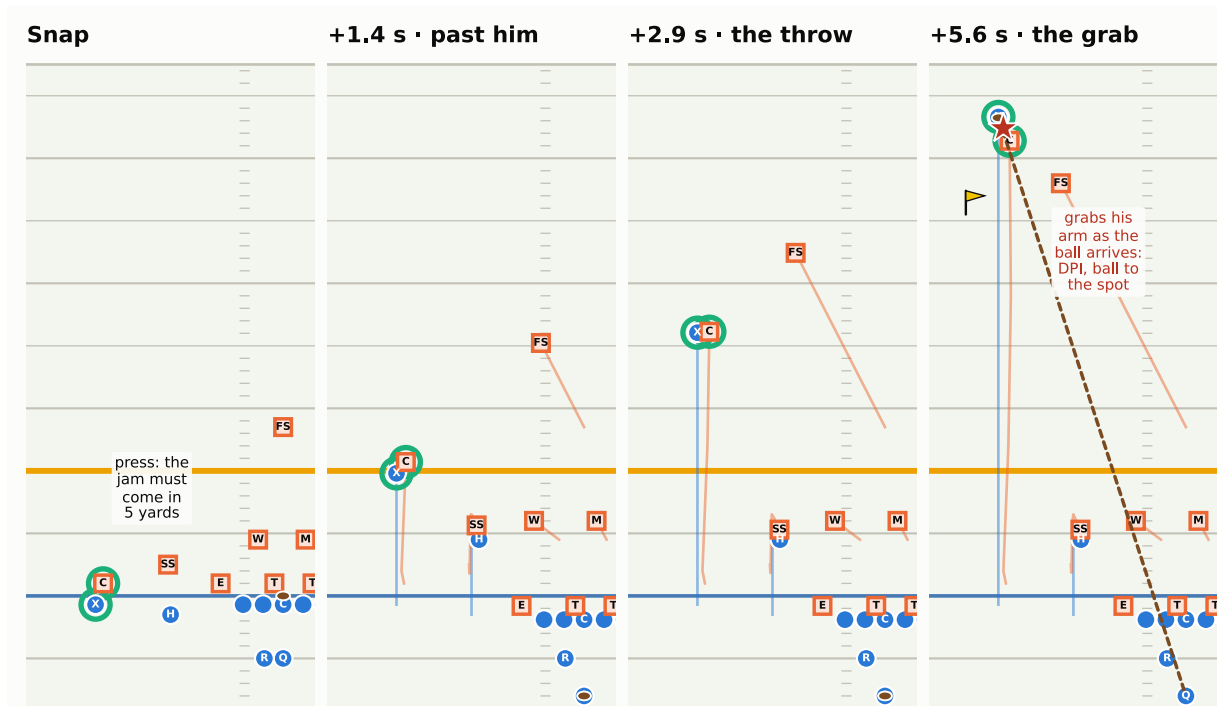


Figure 5: A deep shot against press man, simulated (BDB-format tracking generated by gridiron, not recorded). X beats the press corner (C) off the line, gets a step on him, and the quarterback throws at 2.9 seconds. As the ball comes down, about 37 yards downfield, the trailing corner, a step behind and not looking back for the ball, reaches for X's arm. In the NFL that is first down at the spot of the foul; in college, 15 yards. The free safety (FS) starts in the deep middle and arrives too late to help.

i Film room: Rams at Saints, 2018 NFC Championship (Jan. 20, 2019)

Late in the fourth quarter, the score tied at 20, New Orleans had third-and-10 at the Rams' 13 with about 1:49 to play. Drew Brees threw to Tommylee Lewis near the right sideline, and Rams cornerback Nickell Robey-Coleman, who later said he had been beaten, hit Lewis well before the ball arrived, helmet to helmet. No flag. The Saints kicked a field goal instead of running out the clock from a first down inside the 10, the Rams tied it, and they won 26–23 in overtime.¹⁰

The league admitted the call was missed. Two months later the owners approved a one-year experiment: pass interference, called or not, became **reviewable by replay**, by coach's challenge or, in the last two minutes and overtime, by the replay booth. It was a mess. Replay officials, reluctant to re-referee a judgment call, overturned very few calls or no-calls, coaches stopped challenging, and the rule was allowed to lapse after the 2019 season.¹¹

What to notice: the NFL's experience is why "just review it" isn't simple. Replay works for facts (was his foot down? where was the ball?) and struggles with degree (did he *significantly* hinder him?). Since 2025 the replay booth may help on a short list of fouls, but pass interference is not among them; Officiating, Replay, and the Rules of the Ball covers what replay can and can't do now.

Blocking rules: holding, hands to the face, and where a block may land

Offensive holding is, in most seasons, the most-called foul in the NFL (false starts edged it in 2020 and 2023), and also the one that, by common agreement, officials could call on nearly every snap. Blocking means leverage and hands. The line between blocking a defender and holding him is about *where* the hands are and *what they do*.

¹⁰"2018–19 NFL playoffs," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2018%E2%80%9919_NFL_playoffs (Rams 26, Saints 23, OT, Jan. 20, 2019; the no-call on Robey-Coleman's hit on Lewis with 1:49 left); "Nickell Robey-Coleman," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Nickell_Robey-Coleman . Pro Football Reference box score: <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/boxscores/201901200nor.htm> . Third-and-10 at the Rams' 13 with 1:49 left, tied 20–20: New Orleans Saints, "Turning point of the game in New Orleans Saints loss to Rams": <https://neworleanssaints.com/news/turning-point-of-the-game-in-new-orleans-saints-loss-to-rams>

¹¹"Pass interference," Wikipedia, section on the 2019 replay rule: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pass_interference (owners approved a one-year rule in March 2019 making offensive and defensive pass interference, called or not, reviewable, by challenge or, in the last two minutes of each half and in overtime, by the replay official; it was not renewed for 2020).

Offensive holding is a blocker grabbing, hooking or tackling a defender, or restricting him with hands or arms outside his body's frame. The rule's working idea is the **frame**: the body of the defender below the neck that faces the blocker, in practice the chest plate between his shoulders. A blocker may put his hands inside the frame and push, steer and lock on, and the rule tells him to work his hands there. What he may not do is use his hands or arms to *materially restrict* the defender: grab and turn him, hook him, wrap him up, take him to the ground. The test is the effect, not the hand position (a grab inside the frame that jerks a rusher off his path is still holding), but most flagged holds are a hand outside the frame (cloth at the shoulder, the side of the jersey, an arm). Officials also look at where it happened: a hold away from the point of attack, or on a double team the defender didn't split, is generally not called. Holding costs **ten yards**, usually from the previous spot, and if an offensive player holds in his own end zone, it is a **safety** (two points and the ball to the other team).¹²

Illegal hands to the face is the foul for pushing, punching or grabbing an opponent's face mask, helmet or neck area with the hands. It goes both ways: a lineman who snaps a pass rusher's head back with a palm to the face mask, or a pass rusher who does the same to a blocker. The stat sheet files it as *illegal use of hands*, and the price depends on who did it: **ten yards** against the offense, **five yards and an automatic first down** against the defense.

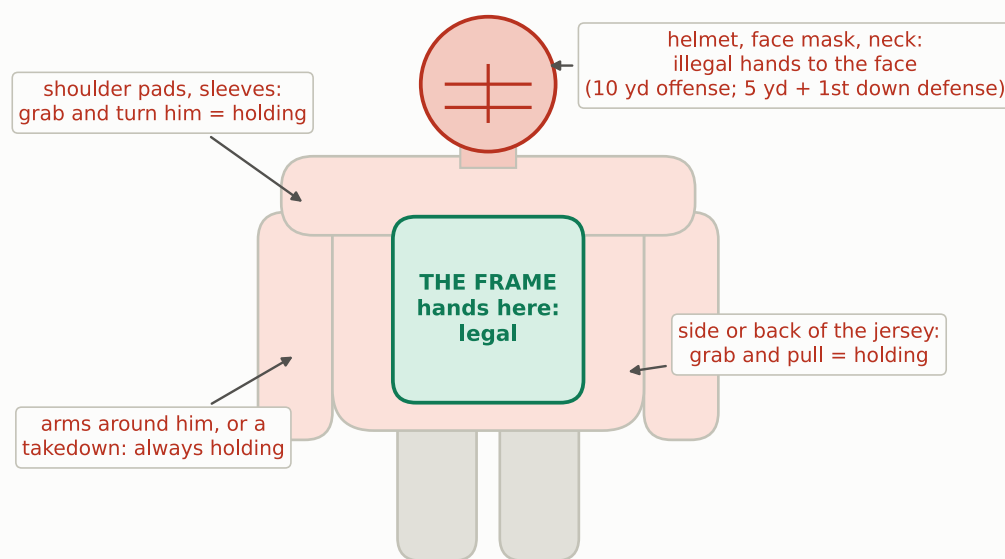


Figure 6: Where a blocker's hands may go, seen from the blocker's side. Inside the frame (the chest plate, between the shoulders), hands may push, steer and lock on: legal. Grabbing outside the frame (shoulder pads, sleeves, the sides and back of the jersey) to turn or restrict him is holding, ten yards against the offense. (Strictly, the test is whether the defender is materially restricted, wherever the hands are; outside the frame is where that usually happens.) Hands to the face mask, helmet or neck are illegal hands to the face for either side. The same rules govern a defender's hands on a receiver before the throw, where the holding foul is five yards and a first down.

Why linemen hold, and why most holds aren't called

Pass protection is a losing fight by design. A pass rusher has to beat one man for a moment; a blocker has to stay in front of him for two and a half seconds or more (Pass Protection). When a rusher wins the edge, the tackle's last resort is his hands, and a grab at the back of the jersey as the rusher turns the corner is the hold you'll see flagged most often. From the lineman's side the trade is sometimes worth it: a sack loses yards, a down and sometimes the ball, while a hold costs ten yards and replays the down.

Officials could find a technical hold on most snaps, so the working standard is narrower: a grab that materially restricts a defender, at or near the point of attack, especially one that turns him, pulls him down or keeps him from the ball. That makes holding unusually sensitive to instructions. In 2020 the league's officiating department told crews to call only "clear and obvious" fouls

¹²NFL, 2026 *Official Playing Rules*, Rule 12, Section 1 Articles 2, 3 and 7 (the frame is "the body of an opponent below the neck that is presented to the blocker"; holding is using hands or arms to "materially restrict or alter the defender's path," "regardless of whether the blocker's hands are inside or outside the frame," ten yards; it is not called away from the point of attack or on an unsplit double team; illegal use of hands to the head or neck, ten yards against the offense and five yards plus an automatic first down against the defense) and Rule 14, Section 2, Article 2 (a foul by the offense behind its own goal line is a safety): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. Most-called foul: course calculation from nflverse play-by-play, offensive holding ahead of false starts in every season 2015–2025 except 2020 (1.79 vs 1.94 a game) and 2023 (2.06 vs 2.27).

rather than “ticky-tack stuff,” and offensive holding flags fell from about 2.8 a game in 2019 to 1.8; they drifted back to about 2.5 by 2024 (the chart below shows it).¹³

i Madden vs. real life

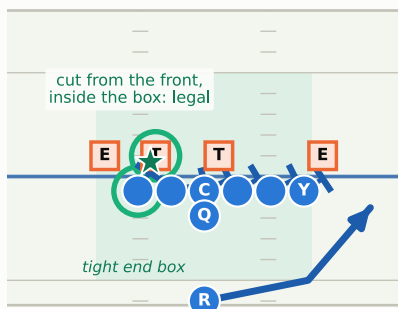
In a video game, holding is a slider: turn it up and the game calls more of it. In the NFL, holding happens on most plays, in small ways, and the question is whether an official sees one that matters. That makes holding calls lumpy: they cluster on edge rushers who win, on run plays at the point of attack, and on crews and seasons with different standards. When the flag comes out, it is usually because a defender was turned, pulled down or had a clear path to the ball taken away by a hand outside the frame, not because a lineman touched a jersey.

Blocks that may not happen: in the back, low, and in pairs

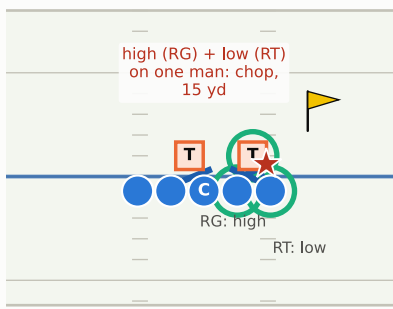
Three more blocking rules shape how plays are drawn:

- **Block in the back.** A block from behind, above the waist, on a player who is not the ball carrier. The NFL’s name for it is an *illegal block above the waist*, and it costs **ten yards**, enforced from the spot of the foul. The same block *below* the waist is **clipping**, fifteen yards. It is the classic foul on kick returns and on screens, where blockers are running toward defenders who have already passed them. It is why return men and screen blockers are coached to “see the numbers, don’t block them”: if you can read the defender’s jersey number on his back, let him go.
- **Cut blocks, with limits.** A cut block (at the thighs or below, from the front) is legal on a scrimmage down only near the ball: inside the *tight end box*, an area that runs from two yards outside each tackle and five yards either side of the line of scrimmage. Outside the box, low blocks are illegal (except against the ball carrier or a player trying to catch a pass), and so is any low block after a change of possession or on a kick. Even inside the box, a low block from behind or from the side while the blocker is moving back toward his own goal line (a *peel-back* block) has been illegal since 2013.¹⁴
- **Chop block.** Two blockers on the same defender, one high and one low at the thigh or below, together or in quick succession. The defender is held up by one and his legs taken out by the other, which is how knees get destroyed. The NFL narrowed the chop for years and banned it in **every situation in 2016**; it costs fifteen yards.

1. Legal cut



2. Chop block



3. Block in the back

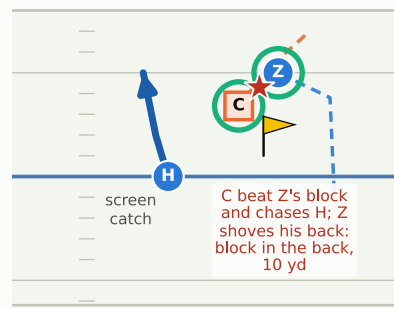


Figure 7: Three blocking rules on the field. 1, a legal cut: on an outside-zone run to the right, the backside tackle cuts the 3-technique tackle from the front, inside the tight end box (shaded: two yards outside each tackle, five yards either side of the line). 2, a chop block: the guard engages the same defensive tackle high and the tackle cuts him low, one defender caught between a high and a low block, fifteen yards. 3, a block in the back: on a screen to H, the cornerback (C) slipped inside Z’s block and is chasing the ball; Z, now behind him, shoves him in the back above the waist, ten yards from the spot of the foul.

¹³Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play: plays whose main foul is offensive holding, 2.81 a game in 2019 and 1.79 in 2020 (both teams, accepted or declined, all plays). The instruction: Kevin Seifert, ESPN, “How the NFL is manipulating games in 2020: Fewer holding calls, faster games and way more offense” (Sept. 30, 2020), quoting Walt Anderson, then head of officiating training, on calling “clear and obvious” fouls and not “ticky-tack stuff”; holding flags were down 59% from 2019 through the first 48 games: https://www.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/30003263

¹⁴NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 3, Section 33 (the tight end box: “two yards outside the normal tackle positions and five yards on either side of the line of scrimmage”), Rule 12, Section 2, Articles 1, 2, 4 and 5 (clipping, 15 yards; peel-back block, 15 yards; blocks below the waist prohibited outside the tight end box on scrimmage downs, after a change of possession and on kicks, 15 yards; “All chop blocks are illegal,” 15 yards) and Rule 12, Section 1, Article 3 (block in the back above the waist: ten yards): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. Peel-back blocks outlawed everywhere in 2013: ProFootballTalk, “NFL bans low blocks from behind” (March 2013): <https://nbcports.com/nfl/profootballtalk/rumor-mill/news/nfl-bans-low-blocks-from-behind>. Chop blocks banned in all situations from 2016: “Chop block,” Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Chop_block

The lineman's one-yard limit, enforced

The last blocking rule belongs to Run-Pass Options, which explains it in full: on a pass, an ineligible lineman whose entire body is more than a yard past the line when the ball is thrown is illegal man downfield, unless he got there while still blocking a defender he engaged at the line. Its price is **five yards from the previous spot**, with no loss of down, and a completed pass is wiped out. Note how that interacts with OPI. A lineman who goes downfield and *blocks* a defender before the pass can be flagged for pass interference instead (ten yards), and a receiver who blocks downfield before the throw is OPI too. That is why NFL RPOs keep everyone's downfield blocking honest until the ball is out. In the data, ineligible-downfield flags rose as RPOs spread through the league, from about 0.06 a game in 2015–2018 to 0.15–0.3 a game in most seasons since 2019 (2020, a light year for flags of every kind, was the exception). The timing fits, though the data can't prove the RPO was the cause.

Player safety: protecting the passer and the defenseless

The rules in this section are newer, mostly 21st century, and they exist for a different reason: not to balance offense against defense but to keep players from being badly hurt, especially in the head, neck and knees. They also cost the most. Almost all of them are **15-yard personal fouls**, with an automatic first down when the defense commits them, and the worst can bring an ejection, a fine or, from 2026, a suspension.

Roughing the passer

A quarterback in the act of throwing can't protect himself. His eyes are downfield, his arm is cocked, his front leg is planted. **Roughing the passer** protects him in that posture and just after. The main ways to commit it:¹⁵

- **Late.** Hitting him after the ball is clearly gone, once the defender has had a reasonable chance to stop (officials think in terms of a step or so).
- **High.** Forcible contact to his head or neck with the helmet, shoulder or forearm, even if the rusher was wrapping him up.
- **Low.** Forcible contact at or below the knees, unless the rusher was blocked into him. This is the "Brady rule," tightened in 2009 after Tom Brady tore knee ligaments on a low hit in the 2008 season opener.
- **Heavy.** Landing on him with all or most of the defender's body weight, or driving him into the ground after the throw. It got a major emphasis in 2018, after Aaron Rodgers broke his collarbone when he was driven into the turf in 2017.
- **Stuffing him.** Picking him up and slamming him, or wrestling him down after the throw.

The price is **15 yards and an automatic first down**; if the pass is completed, the 15 yards are walked off from the previous spot or the end of the play, whichever helps the offense more, so a completion usually keeps its yards and gets the 15 on top. That makes roughing one of the most expensive defensive fouls (see the chart in What penalties cost), and also one of the most argued, because it asks an official to judge a 270-pound man's momentum in half a second. Two roughing calls on consecutive days in October 2022, on Atlanta's Grady Jarrett for his sack of Tom Brady and on Kansas City's Chris Jones for a strip-sack of Derek Carr, set off a week of debate about whether the rule had gone too far.¹⁶

¹⁵NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 12, Section 2, Article 11 (roughing the passer: contact allowed only through the rusher's first step after the release; forcible contact to the head or neck; forcible contact at or below the knee unless blocked into the passer; landing with all or most of the body weight; 15 yards and an automatic first down) and Rule 8, Section 6, Article 1(d) (a defensive personal foul before a completion is enforced from the previous spot or the dead-ball spot, whichever is more beneficial to the offense): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. History: "Roughing the passer," Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Roughing_the_passer (the 2009 low-hit rule after Brady's September 2008 knee injury; the 2018 body-weight emphasis after Rodgers's 2017 broken collarbone).

¹⁶The Week 5 2022 calls on Grady Jarrett (Falcons at Buccaneers, Sunday Oct. 9, 2022) and Chris Jones (Raiders at Chiefs, Monday Oct. 10, 2022): Fox News, "Chiefs' Chris Jones called for 'very questionable' roughing the passer penalty": <https://www.foxnews.com/sports/chiefs-chris-jones-called-very-questionable-roughing-passer-penalty-nfl-fans-express-displeasure>; AP, "Brady fined \$11K for attempted kick of Jarrett" (Oct. 15, 2022): <https://news4jax.com/sports/2022/10/15/ap-source-brady-fined-11k-for-attempted-kick-of-jarrett>

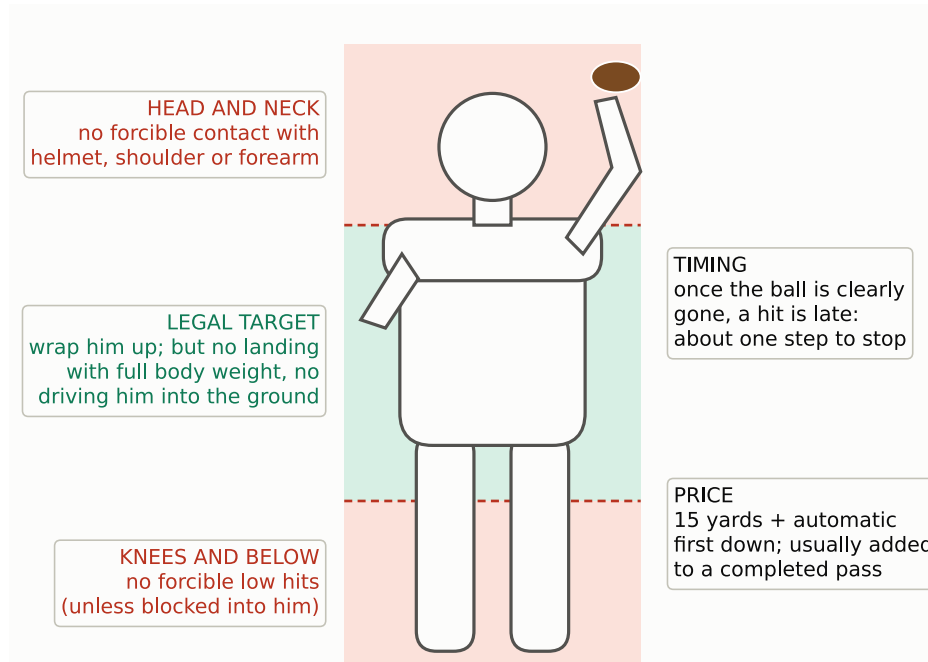


Figure 8: The passer's protected zones, as the rules describe them. Head and neck: no forcible contact with the helmet, face mask, shoulder or forearm, even on a sack. Knees and below: no forcible low hits unless the rusher has been blocked into him (the 2009 'Brady rule'). Between them is the legal target, but a rusher may not land on him with most of his body weight or drive him into the ground, and any hit once the ball is clearly gone is late. Each foul is 15 yards and an automatic first down.

The sliding quarterback and the defenseless player

When a quarterback runs, he becomes a runner and can be tackled like one, with one exception. If he **slides feet first**, he is giving himself up: the ball is dead the instant he touches the ground with anything but his hands or feet, and defenders must treat him like a runner already down by contact and pull up. A quarterback who *fakes* a slide is treated as having slid (the ball is dead when he begins the fake), so he can't use it to freeze a defender and keep running. The current rule treats a dive, feet or head first, the same way as a slide.¹⁷

The **defenseless player** rule generalises the idea. The rule book lists players who can't protect themselves: a passer in the act of throwing or just after; a receiver trying to catch a pass (and until he has had time to protect himself after the catch); a runner already held up with his forward progress stopped; a kicker or punter during the kick; a kick returner fielding the ball; a quarterback after a change of possession; a player on the ground; a player hit by an illegal blindside block; a receiver running his route when the defender comes from the side or behind; and a few others. Against them a defender may not make forcible contact to the head or neck with the helmet, face mask, shoulder or forearm, and may not **launch** (leave his feet and spring upward and forward into the player). The foul is **unnecessary roughness**, the catch-all personal foul that also covers late hits after the whistle and hits on players out of bounds: **15 yards**, with an automatic first down when the defense commits it.¹⁸

The defenseless-player rule is why you see safeties aiming low, at a receiver's thighs, on a pass over the middle instead of "lighting him up" high. It is a rule that changed how a position is played.

The 2018 helmet rule

In 2018 the NFL went further with the **use of the helmet (2018 rule)**: it is a foul for **any player, anywhere on the field**, to lower his head to initiate and make contact with his helmet against an opponent. Unlike the defenseless-player rules, it covers runners and blockers as well as tacklers, and it applies to everyone on every play, not just to hits on certain players. The penalty

¹⁷NFL, 2026 *Official Playing Rules*, Rule 7, Section 2, Article 1(d)(2) and Notes: "When a runner slides or dives feet or head first or simulates sliding or diving, the ball is dead the instant he touches the ground with anything other than his hands or his feet, or begins to simulate touching the ground"; defenders "are required to treat a sliding or diving runner as they would a runner who is down by contact" and must pull up when the slide begins; late hits on him are unnecessary roughness (Rule 12, Section 2, Article 8(d)): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. On officiating the fake slide, Walt Anderson quoted in Kevin Seifert, ESPN, "NFL continues to grapple with rules on late quarterback hits" (Dec. 31, 2024): <https://abc7news.com/post/nfl-continues-grapple-rules-late-quarterback-hits/15732633/>

¹⁸NFL, 2026 *Official Playing Rules*, Rule 12, Section 2, Article 9 (the eleven categories of players in a defenseless posture; prohibited contact against them, including launching; 15 yards and an automatic first down) and Article 8 (unnecessary roughness; 15 yards, plus an automatic first down if by the defense): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

is **15 yards**, and a flagrant violation can be an ejection.¹⁹ In the nflverse data the foul appears under its own name, “lowering the head to initiate contact,” at about 0.07 to 0.13 flags a game from 2018 to 2020, and then vanishes from the labels after 2021. Whether those calls dried up or are now filed under another name (unnecessary roughness is the likely home), the series breaks there. That is a good warning for anyone charting penalty data: categories move.

Tackles that are banned: the horse-collar and the hip-drop

Two tackles are illegal by name:

- **Horse-collar tackle** (banned in 2005). Grabbing the inside back or side collar of a runner’s shoulder pads or jersey and pulling him down, usually from behind. The runner’s legs fold under him as he falls backward, which breaks ankles and tears knee ligaments. The ban followed the 2004 season, in which Dallas safety Roy Williams’s horse-collar tackles injured several players, among them Philadelphia’s Terrell Owens.²⁰ 15 yards and an automatic first down.
- **Hip-drop tackle** (banned in 2024). The tackler wraps the runner from behind or the side, swings his hips and legs off the ground, and drops his weight onto the runner’s legs at or below the knee. The league’s injury data showed the technique injuring runners at a far higher rate than ordinary tackles, and the owners banned it in March 2024, unanimously and over the objections of the players’ union, with a 15-yard penalty and an automatic first down.²¹

Discipline beyond the flag: the 2026 three-strike policy

A flag is only one price. Players are also fined, and the worst hits bring suspensions. For the 2026 season the league and the players’ union agreed on a **three-strike policy** for five listed fouls (hip-drop tackles, horse-collar tackles, launching, hits on a defenseless player, and blindside blocks): three violations bring a one-game suspension, and the strikes carry over into later seasons. Everyone started the 2026 regular season with a clean slate. Reports differ on one detail: the Associated Press describes three violations across the categories, while ProFootballTalk reads the policy as three violations of the *same* rule. Strikes come from the league’s discipline after review, not only from flags.²² The point is to reach the habits that flags and fines hadn’t changed, especially for the hip-drop, which is rarely flagged (below).

¹⁹NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 12, Section 2 (use of the helmet: it is a foul if a player lowers his head to initiate and make contact with his helmet against an opponent; 15 yards, and a player may be disqualified): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/> . Adopted at the annual meeting in Orlando on March 27, 2018: *Sports Illustrated*, “NFL Owners Approve Targeting Rule: Lowering Head to Initiate Contact With Helmet is a Penalty”: <https://www.si.com/nfl/2018/03/27/annual-league-meeting-targeting-rule-head> . nflverse labels: course calculation, “Lowering the Head to Initiate Contact” 0.07, 0.11 and 0.13 flags a game in 2018–2020, 0.04 in 2021, and none labelled so from 2022.

²⁰“Horse-collar tackle,” Wikipedia: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Horse-collar_tackle (banned by the NFL in May 2005 after injuries caused by Roy Williams’s tackles in 2004, including Terrell Owens’s). The owners’ 27–5 vote in May 2005, and Williams’s 2004 horse-collar tackles on Owens (fractured fibula, torn ankle ligaments), Tennessee’s Tyrone Calico and Baltimore’s Musa Smith: *New York Sun*, “A Tweak to the NFL Rule Book Yields Scant Results”: <https://www.nysun.com/article/sports-tweak-to-the-nfl-rule-book-yields-scant-results> ; *Las Vegas Sun* (May 27, 2005): <https://m.lasvegassun.com/news/2005/may/27/cowboys-williams-says-he-will-not-use-banned-techn/> . Current rule: *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 12, Section 2, Article 16 (15 yards and an automatic first down).

²¹NFL.com, “NFL owners vote to ban hip-drop tackle at annual league meeting” (March 2024): a 15-yard penalty and an automatic first down: <https://www.nfl.com/news/nfl-owners-vote-to-ban-hip-drop-tackle-at-annual-league-meeting> . The unanimous vote, the league’s finding of an injury rate 20 to 25 times that of other tackles, and the NFLPA’s objection: CBS Sports, “NFL players seem irate after owners unanimously approve new rule that bans hip-drop tackles” (March 2024): <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/nfl-players-seem-irate-after-owners-unanimously-approve-new-rule-that-bans-hip-drop-tackles> . Current rule: *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 12, Section 2, Article 18.

²²Associated Press, “Players will be suspended 1 game if they accumulate 3 penalties in certain categories” (Aug. 26, 2026; the five categories, the one-game suspension, carry-over “into subsequent seasons,” a clean slate for all players, half the fine refunded for a single violation): <https://www.adn.com/sports/national-sports/2026/08/26/nfl-players-will-be-suspended-1-game-if-they-accumulate-3-penalties-in-certain-categories/> ; NBC Sports (ProFootballTalk), “NFL’s new three-strike system doesn’t apply until the 2026 regular season” (August 2026; “a one-game suspension happens only if a player violates the same rule three times”): <https://www.nbcsports.com/nfl/profootballtalk/rumor-mill/news/nfls-new-three-strike-system-doesnt-apply-until-the-2026-regular-season>

Table 1: The main player-safety rules and when they arrived. Personal fouls by the defense carry an automatic first down; flagrant ones can bring an ejection. Sources in the footnotes to this section.

Rule	Since	What it bans	Price on the field	Why it was written
Horse-collar tackle	2005	Pulling a runner down by the back or side collar	15 yd + 1st down	Leg and ankle injuries from runners folded backward
Low hit on the passer (“Brady rule”)	2009	Forcible hits at or below a passer’s knees	15 yd + 1st down	Knee injuries to quarterbacks
Chop block (all situations)	2016	High-low double blocks	15 yd	Knee injuries to linemen
Use of the helmet	2018	Lowering the head to initiate helmet contact, anyone, anywhere	15 yd, possible ejection	Head and neck injuries to both players
Roughing: body weight emphasis	2018	Landing on the passer with most of the body weight	15 yd + 1st down	Shoulder and collarbone injuries to quarterbacks
Hip-drop tackle	2024	Swinging the hips onto a runner’s legs	15 yd + 1st down	Lower-leg injuries to runners
Three-strike policy	2026	Repeat violations of five listed safety rules	One-game suspension after three	Repeat offenders flags didn’t deter

! Why it exists: safety rules with a scheme side effect

What they solve. Head, neck and knee injuries that a career, or a life, can’t recover from. **What they change.** Defensive backs tackle lower and play the ball instead of the man; rushers learn to hit the quarterback’s torso and roll off him; offenses gain yards on every borderline call, and a quarterback who slides gets a free end to his run. Each rule also creates a judgment call, and judgment calls on 15-yard fouls swing games. That tension, between protecting players and leaving the officials too much to decide, runs through every live rules debate.

How a flag becomes yards: enforcement

Now the mechanics. When a flag flies during a play, the officials answer a fixed sequence of questions. Learn them and you can usually announce the result before the referee does.

Accept or decline

Most fouls happen during a live play, and the play keeps going until it ends normally. Then the team that was fouled gets a choice: **accept or decline**. Accept, and the result of the play is usually wiped out and the penalty enforced. Decline, and the play stands as though no foul happened.²³ In practice the head coach decides, quickly, with the referee explaining the options to the team captain or the coach on the sideline.

The choice is usually obvious (nobody declines a 40-yard DPI) but not always:

- **Third down, incomplete pass, offensive holding.** Accept, and it’s third-and-18 from ten yards back. Decline, and it’s fourth-and-8: the offense will probably punt. Most defenses decline, because a stop now beats a long third down later. In 2021–2025 offenses converted third-and-16 to third-and-20 about 10% of the time; a declined penalty that forces the punt takes even that chance away.
- **Defensive offside on a touchdown pass.** The offense declines and keeps the touchdown.
- **A sack and a hold.** If the offense held and the quarterback was sacked anyway for 9 yards, the defense can take the sack (and the down) or the 10 yards (and replay the down), whichever leaves the offense worse off.
- **Fouls by both teams** on the same play usually **offset**: the penalties cancel and the down is replayed.

²³NFL, *2026 Official Playing Rules*, Rule 14, Section 1 (“the penalty for any foul may be declined by the offended team and play proceeds as though no foul had been committed”; fouls by both teams offset) and Rule 3 (live-ball and dead-ball fouls): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

Some fouls aren't part of the choice in the usual way. Fouls *after* the play is over (a late hit, a taunt, a fight) are **dead-ball fouls**: the play's result stands and the yardage is added on, from where the play ended. That's how a 20-yard completion plus a late hit becomes 35 yards.

Free plays

Free play is the accept-or-decline option seen from the other end. When a defender jumps offside and the offense snaps the ball before he can get back, the play goes on with the flag already down. The offense can't lose: if the play works, it declines the penalty and keeps the result; if it fails (incomplete, sacked, even intercepted), it takes the five yards. Coaches teach quarterbacks to recognise the jump and take a shot downfield, usually a deep throw they would never risk otherwise. The same thing happens when a twelfth defender is still running off the field at the snap (What a Play Really Is), and it's one reason quarterbacks use a hard count to draw defenders across (The Pre-Snap Phase, which also counts how often offenses declined an offside flag in 2025).

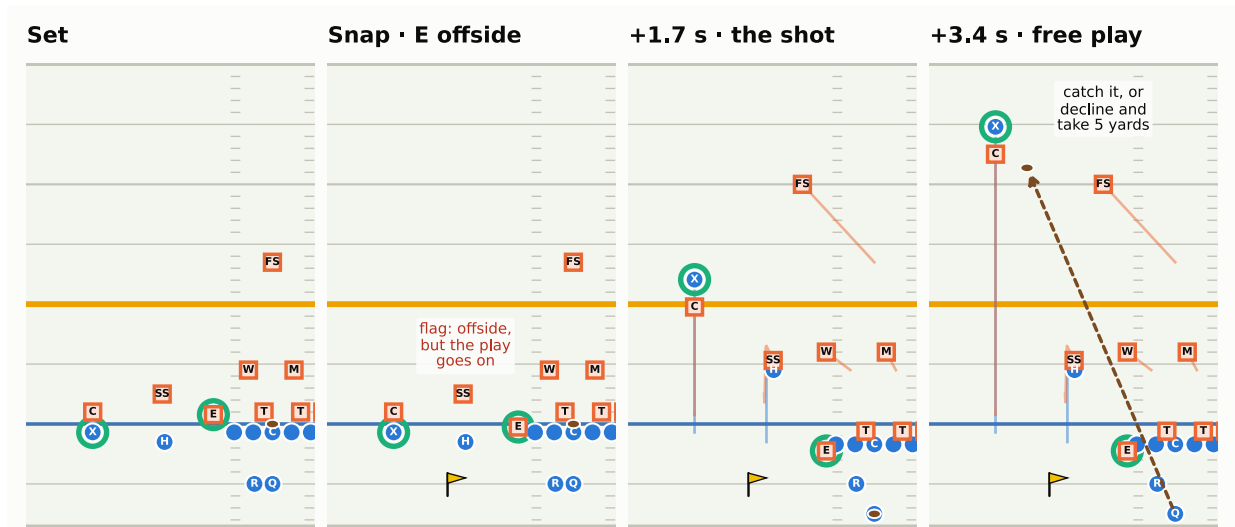


Figure 9: A free play, simulated (BDB-format tracking generated by gridiron). Before the snap the left defensive end (E) jumps into the neutral zone; the center snaps the ball before he can get back, so the officials throw the flag but let the play run. The quarterback, knowing the offense can take five yards if this goes badly, throws deep to X against the press corner, a throw he would rarely risk on a normal second down. If X catches it, the offense declines the penalty; if it falls incomplete or is intercepted, the offense accepts it and replays the down five yards closer.

From which spot, and how far

If the penalty is accepted, the officials need a starting point and a distance:

- **The previous spot** (where the ball was snapped) is the default for most fouls, including all pre-snap fouls, offensive pass interference, defensive holding and illegal contact, and most offensive holding on pass plays.
- **The spot of the foul** is used for defensive pass interference (the spot foul) and, generally, for fouls by the offense beyond the line on running plays and on kick returns: a block in the back 20 yards upfield on a punt return is walked off from where it happened.
- **The end of the play** (the *succeeding spot*) is used for dead-ball fouls after the whistle, and is an option for a defensive personal foul such as roughing the passer on a completed pass (the offense gets whichever of the previous spot and the end of the play helps it more).

Then **how far**: five, ten or fifteen yards, or the spot. And then two adjustments near the goal lines:

- **Half the distance.** A penalty may not move the ball more than halfway to the offending team's goal line. Holding by the offense on its own 8 moves the ball to the 4, not to the end zone. A defensive personal foul with the ball on the opponent's 6 moves it to the 3. Without the rule, a penalty could score points; with it, the ball keeps creeping toward the goal line but never gets there.²⁴
- **Fouls in the end zone.** Offensive holding in the offense's own end zone is a **safety**. DPI in the end zone puts the ball on the 1.

²⁴NFL, 2026 Official Playing Rules, Rule 14 (a penalty may not move the ball more than half the distance from the enforcement spot to the offending team's goal line): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>

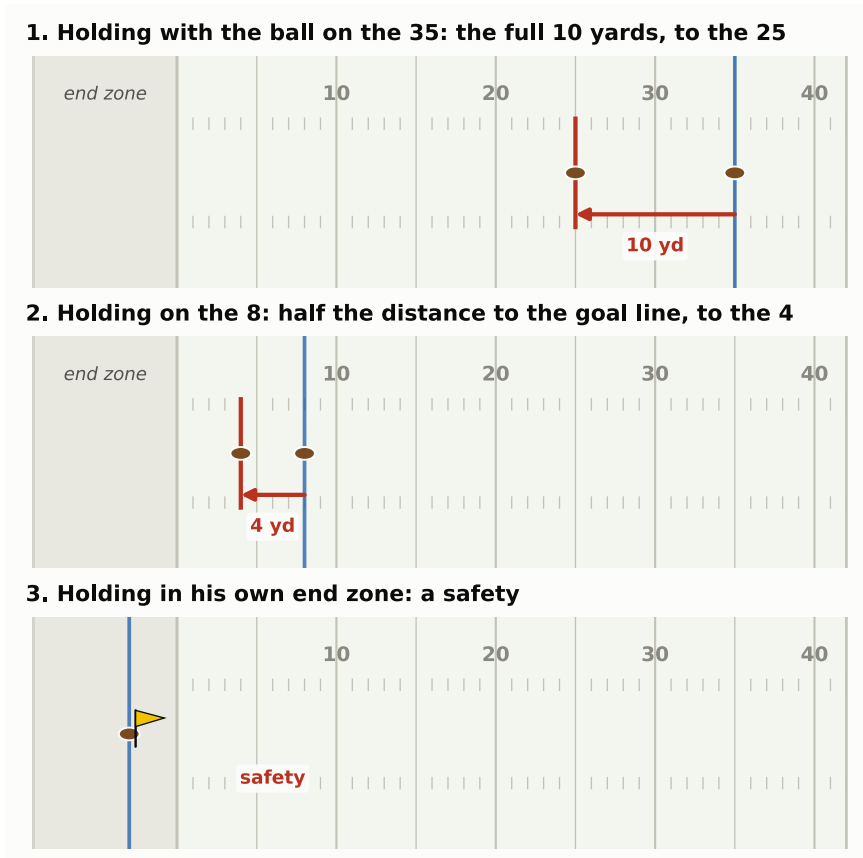


Figure 10: The same offensive holding call, ten yards, at three spots near the offense's own goal line (offense moving right). Top: from the 35 the full 10 yards apply, so the next snap is at the 25. Middle: from the 8, ten yards would carry the ball into the end zone, so it moves half the distance to the goal line, to the 4. Bottom: if the hold happens in the offense's own end zone, it is a safety: two points to the defense, and the offense must free-kick.

What down is it?

Last question: the down.

- **Fouls by the offense** usually **replay the down**: second-and-10 becomes second-and-20 after a hold. A few also cost a down (an illegal forward pass, intentional grounding; see Officiating, Replay, and the Rules of the Ball).
- **Fouls by the defense** come in two kinds. The pre-snap and procedural fouls (offside, encroachment, neutral zone infraction, too many men) replay the down unless the yards reach the line to gain. The contact and safety fouls (defensive holding, illegal contact, DPI, roughing the passer, unnecessary roughness and the other personal fouls, illegal hands to the face) carry an **automatic first down**, however short the yardage.
- **A half can't end on an accepted defensive foul during a play.** If time runs out on a play with a defensive foul and the offense accepts, it gets one untimed down. (That is why Hail Mary throws go *into* the end zone; see the second drill below.)

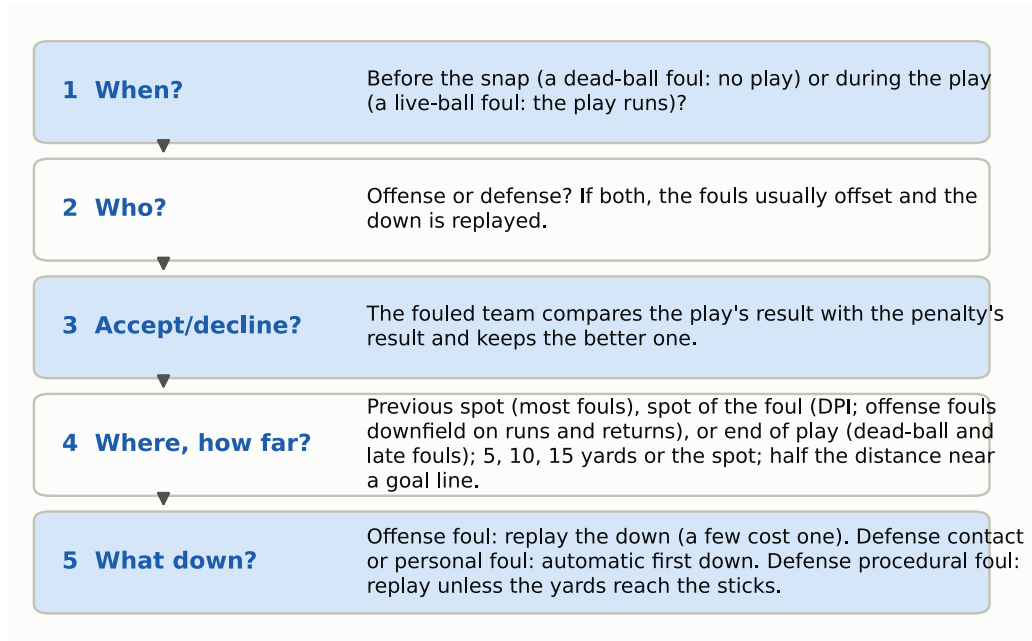


Figure 11: What happens when a flag flies: the officials' sequence, and yours. Answer the five questions in order and you can announce the result before the referee does.

What penalties cost

Now price them. Every NFL game has about 13 fouls named in the play-by-play (both teams, accepted or declined, in 2025), and a handful of types account for most of them.

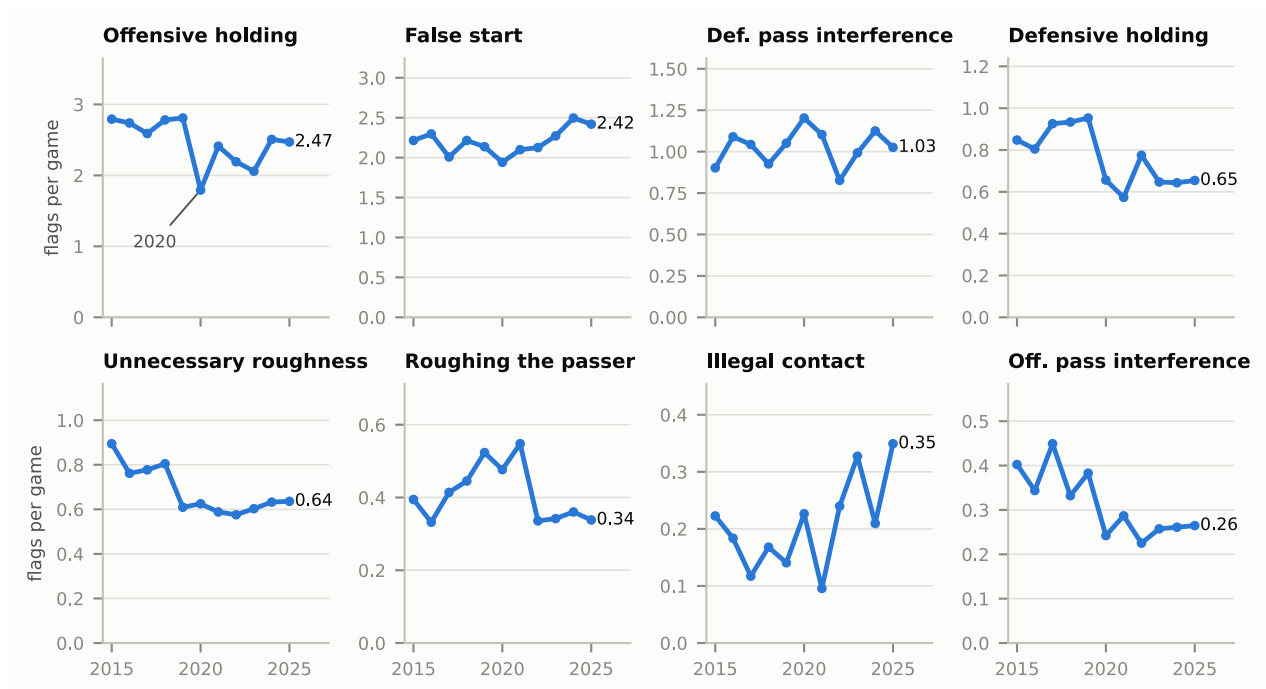


Figure 12: Flags per game (both teams) for eight common fouls, 2015-2025 regular seasons. Offensive holding and false starts are the two most common by far. Holding dropped sharply in 2020, when officials were told to call it less, and has since climbed back. Roughing the passer peaked in 2018-2021 after the body-weight emphasis and fell back from 2022. Illegal contact jumps around from year to year, as emphasis changes. Source: nflverse play-by-play, one foul per play (the play's main foul), accepted or declined, all plays including kicks; each panel has its own scale.

How often a foul is called is half the story. The other half is what each one is worth. Because nflverse computes expected points before and after every snap, a penalty snap gets an EPA like any other: the value of the down, distance and yard line after the flag,

minus the value before. (That includes the play the flag wiped out, which is gone; the EPA reflects only where the penalty left the ball.) Averaging by foul type gives a price list in points.

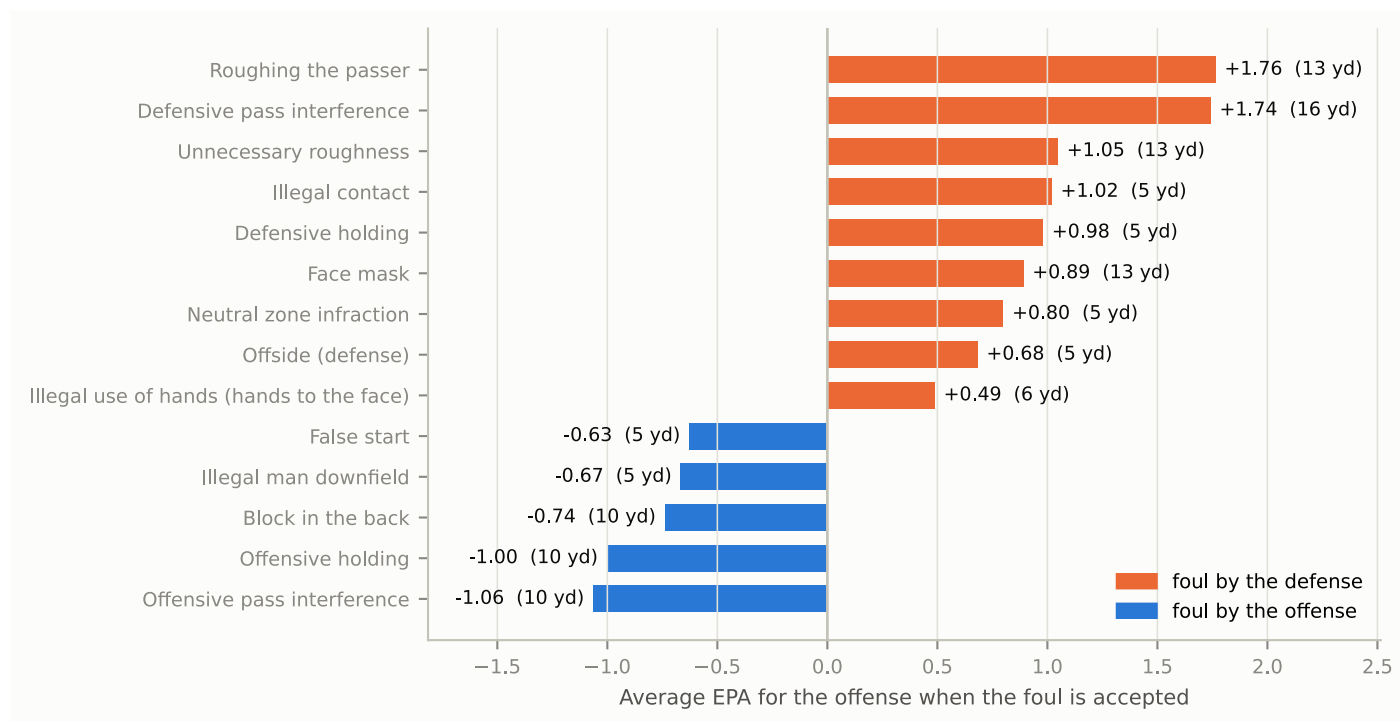


Figure 13: The average swing in expected points (EPA, from the offense's point of view) when a foul is accepted, 2021-2025 regular seasons, scrimmage downs. Fouls by the defense (orange) help the offense; fouls by the offense (blue) hurt it. The number on each bar is the average penalty yardage. Illegal use of hands, face mask and unnecessary roughness can be on either team; each is drawn in the colour of the side that commits it most often. Source: nflverse play-by-play.

Four things stand out.

1. **The automatic first down is worth more than the yards.** Defensive holding and illegal contact are five-yard fouls, the same yardage as a false start, yet they swing about a point toward the offense while a false start costs about two-thirds of one the other way. The first down is the expensive part.
2. **DPI and roughing the passer cost a defense more than a completed pass usually gains.** The average completion in these seasons was worth about +0.80 EPA; a DPI flag averaged +1.74, and roughing +1.76.
3. **Offensive holding is a drive-killer.** At about -1.00 EPA, a hold costs a little over half of what a sack does (-1.78 on average), and holds are flagged about two and a half times a game.
4. **The same five-yard foul is worth more on later downs.** The table shows it.

Table 2: The same five-yard defensive foul (defensive holding or illegal contact, accepted) by down, 2021-2025 regular seasons. Each carries an automatic first down, so its value rises as the down gets later: on third down it erases a likely punt. Source: nflverse play-by-play.

Down	Flags	Average yards to go	Average EPA for the offense
1st	423	10.0	+0.45
2nd	339	8.2	+0.87
3rd	382	7.2	+1.52
4th	42	5.5	+2.61

On first-and-10 a defensive hold is a modest gain, first-and-5. On third-and-7 it erases a likely punt and hands the offense a fresh set of downs, so it's worth about three times as much. That's why defensive coordinators preach discipline on third down above all, and why an offense with a long third down will often throw toward the corner it thinks is most likely to grab.

i Go deeper: penalties in EPA work

Analysts don't agree on how to treat penalty snaps. The usual "EPA per play" leaves out snaps that a penalty wiped out (nflverse marks them `play_type == "no_play"`), which drops most DPI flags and most holding calls from team numbers. Expected Points and Success Rate shows how much that choice shades run-versus-pass comparisons; the DPI flags alone make passing look a little better once they are counted. For your own work: say which choice you made, and remember that nflverse records one foul per play, so a play with two flags carries only one penalty type.

The rules keep moving: live debates

Every spring the competition committee and the teams propose rule changes, and the owners vote; a change needs 24 of 32 votes. The rules in this chapter will keep changing, so here are the debates that were live going into the 2026 season. (For how these fit the long history of rule changes, see *The 1978 Liberation and Dynasties and Counterpunches*; for the timeline, Appendix E.)

- **The tush push.** The tush push is a quarterback sneak with teammates shoving the quarterback from behind, the Eagles' near-automatic short-yardage play (Red Zone, Goal Line, Two-Point Plays, and Short Yardage explains it). Pushing the runner has been legal since the NFL removed its ban in 2005. In 2025 Green Bay proposed banning it again; the proposal was tabled in the spring and a revised version **failed 22–10 on May 21, 2025**, two votes short of 24. The league tightened its officiating guidance on false starts and alignment instead. For 2026, **no team proposed a ban**, and the play is legal this season.²⁵ The argument is about safety (a pile of linemen driving forward), about fairness (is a nearly unstoppable play bad for the game?) and about whether one team's mastery of a play is a reason to outlaw it. The case study is *The Eagles: Trenches, RPOs, and the Tush Push*.
- **Is the hip-drop ban being enforced?** The tackle was banned in 2024, but on-field flags have been extremely rare: nflverse's play-by-play records 1 hip-drop flag in the 2024 regular season and 2 in 2025. The technique happens in a blur, from behind, in a pile, which is hard for an official to see live. The league has leaned on fines after the game instead, and the 2026 three-strike policy adds suspensions on top. Whether discipline after the fact changes behaviour as much as flags would is the open question.
- **Replay for judgment calls.** After the 2019 pass-interference experiment failed, the NFL moved more carefully. Since 2025 the replay assistant may help the referee on objective facts and may **overturn** flags for hits on a defenseless player, face mask, horse-collar, tripping and roughing or running into the kicker. It **cannot add** a foul that wasn't called, and roughing the passer and pass interference are not on the list. In 2026 league officials may also be consulted on ejections for flagrant acts.²⁶ Proposals for a full "sky judge" who could call fouls from the booth keep coming back.
- **College versus NFL.** The college game caps DPI at 15 yards, gives linemen three yards downfield instead of one, and treats targeting (a forcible hit to the head) with automatic ejections. College offensive pass interference was cut from 15 yards to 10 for 2026.²⁷ Each difference is a live argument for moving the NFL rule toward college, or the reverse; the full side-by-side table is in Appendix E and the history in *The College Laboratory*.

²⁵Green Bay's 2025 proposal and the 22–10 vote on May 21, 2025: SI, "Packers' proposal to ban Eagles' tush push fails again": <https://www.si.com/nfl/packers/packers-proposal-to-ban-eagles-tush-push-fails-again> ; no proposal for 2026: NFL.com, "Competition committee co-chairman Rich McKay doesn't expect tush push ban proposal in 2026": <https://www.nfl.com/news/competition-committee-co-chairman-rich-mckay-doesn-t-expect-tush-push-ban-proposal-in-2026> , and The Washington Times (Feb. 24, 2026): <https://www.washingtontimes.com/news/2026/feb/24/nfl-receives-no-tush-push-ban-proposal-year-effort-last-year-ban/> . The 2005 removal of the ban on pushing the runner (pulling him is still a foul): *Boston Globe*, "How the tush push became legal" coverage (April 2, 2025), quoting former officiating chief Mike Pereira that pushing was "really too difficult to officiate. Therefore, we just said, 'OK, it's legal to push'": <https://www.bostonglobe.com/2025/04/02/sports/nfl-tush-push-rule/> ; current rule, 2026 *Official Playing Rules*, Rule 12, Section 1, Article 4 ("No offensive player may pull a runner in any direction at any time").

²⁶CBS Sports, "Five new NFL rules to know heading into Week 1 of preseason" (2025): <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/five-new-nfl-rules-to-know-heading-into-week-1-of-preseason-here-are-the-biggest-changes-for-2025> ; Seahawks.com, "NFL announces approved rule changes for 2026 season": <https://www.seahawks.com/news/nfl-announces-approved-rule-changes-for-2026-season>

²⁷National Football Foundation summary of 2026 college rule changes ("The penalty for offensive pass interference is being adjusted from 15 yards to 10 yards"; the first targeting disqualification of a season no longer carries into the next game), reported in the *Altoona Mirror*, "College football changing target rule penalty" (Aug. 11, 2026): <https://www.altoonamirror.com/sports/psu/2026/08/cfb-nff-rules-targeting-penalty-changing/> . College linemen may be up to three yards downfield on a pass that crosses the neutral zone: NCAA Rule 7-3-10, summarised by the San Diego County Football Officials Association: <https://www.sdcfoa.org/ncaa/rule-7-snapping-and-passing-the-ball/college-7-3-10>

💡 Watch for it on Sunday: the flag predictor

Every time a yellow flag flies, play referee before the referee does. Say your answers out loud, then check them against the announcement.

- **Where did the flag come from?** The official's position is a clue. A flag from deep downfield (the side judges, field judge or back judge) is usually pass interference, illegal contact or defensive holding. A flag from the officials at the line of scrimmage or behind the offense is usually holding, a false start or a foul on the quarterback. A flag thrown late, after the play, is usually a personal foul. (Who stands where is in Officiating, Replay, and the Rules of the Ball.)
- **Was the ball in the air?** If a receiver was grabbed before the throw, guess holding or illegal contact (five yards, first down). After the throw, guess DPI and estimate the spot.
- **Accept or decline?** Ask what the fouled team gave up on the play. Third-down incompletion plus an offensive hold: expect a decline and a punt.
- **Enforce it.** Which spot, how far, half the distance near a goal line, and what down. Say the new down and distance.
- **Free play?** If a defender jumped and the ball was snapped anyway, watch the quarterback take his shot.
- **Keep score.** By the end of a game you'll be calling most flags right. For a running tally, log the penalties' expected-points cost from the chart in What penalties cost: which team gave away more points in flags?

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play 1: a flag on third down

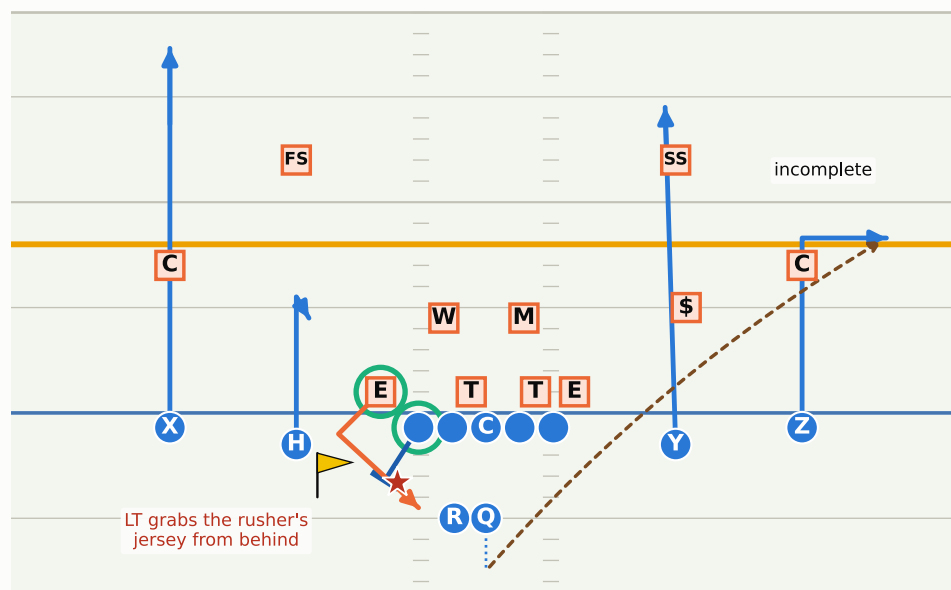


Figure 14: Third-and-8 at the offense's own 40. The left tackle, beaten around the edge, grabs the rusher's jersey from behind, and a flag flies. The pass to Z falls incomplete.

The defense gets to choose. Does it accept the holding penalty or decline it? What happens next either way?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 2: the last snap

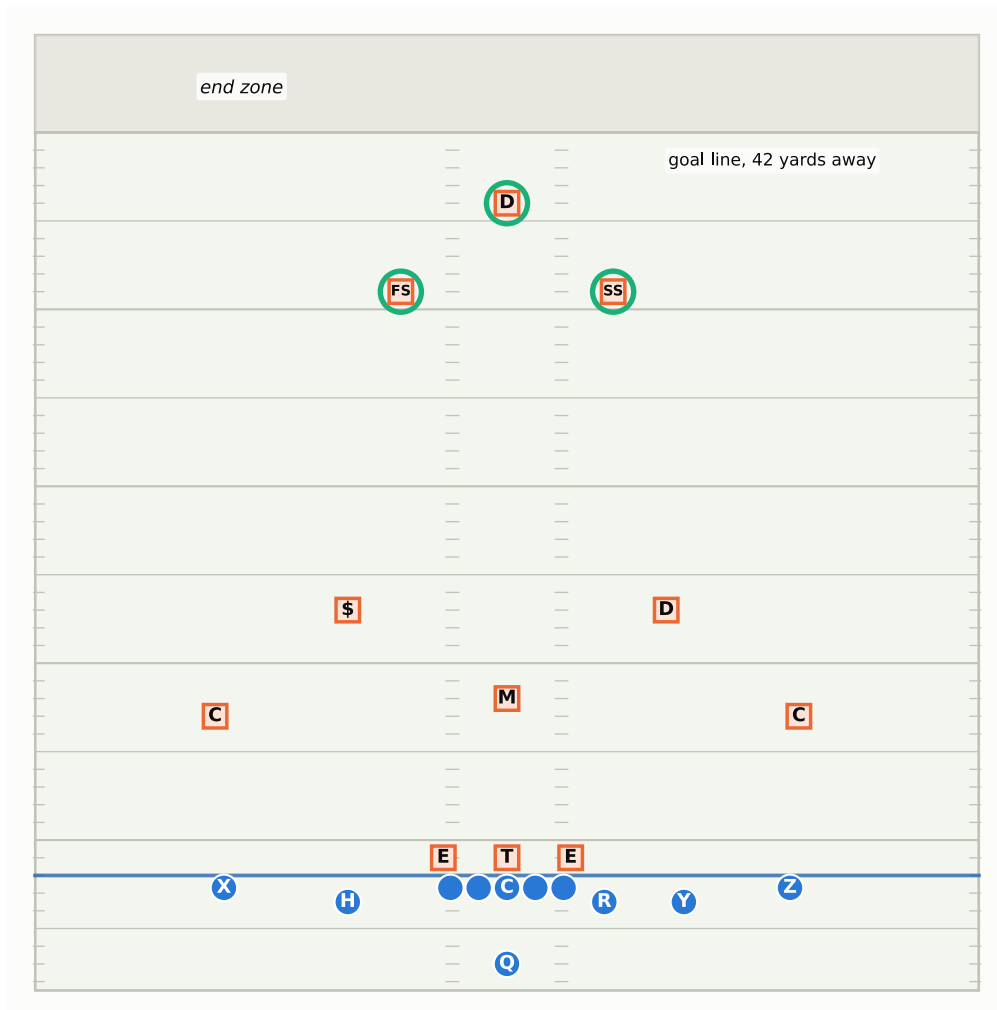


Figure 15: Fourth quarter, 0:04 left, the offense trails by 5 with the ball at the opponent's 42 and no timeouts. Five receivers spread out; the defense rushes three and drops eight, three of them near the goal line.

What will the offense try, where will the ball be thrown, and why there rather than ten yards short, where a receiver might be open?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play 3: bunch on third-and-3

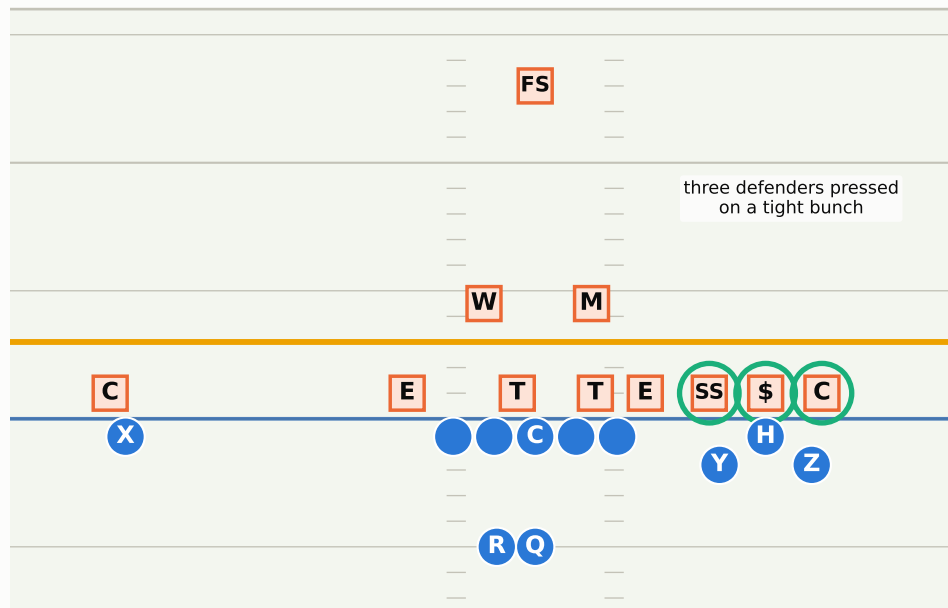


Figure 16: Third-and-3 at midfield. The offense lines up in a tight bunch to the right. The defense shows press man coverage on all three bunch receivers (the ringed defenders, each a yard off the ball), with one deep safety.

What kind of route combination should the offense call here? Where must the contact happen for it to be legal? And what could the defense have done differently before the snap?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- **The rule book is a price list, and teams shop.** Five yards, ten, fifteen, the spot, a first down, a safety, an ejection: every foul has a price, and coaches decide when it's worth paying (the beaten corner's grab, the beaten tackle's hold, the deep throw hunting a flag).
- **A receiver's rules change with depth and with the throw.** Inside five yards, jam him. Past five, hands off until the ball is in the air (illegal contact, defensive holding: five yards and a first down). After the throw, play the ball (DPI: a spot foul in the NFL, 15 yards in college). The offense's restrictions start at the snap; pick plays are legal only inside the first yard.
- **The spot foul shapes offense.** Because DPI has no cap in the NFL, deep throws into tight coverage carry a hidden bonus, and big receivers who win 50-50 balls or draw flags are worth more.
- **Blocking is about the frame.** Hands inside the chest plate that push and steer are legal; grabbing that materially restricts a defender (usually a hand outside the frame), hands to the face, blocks in the back, cuts outside the tight end box and chop blocks are not. Holding is usually the most-called foul and the most sensitive to officiating emphasis.
- **Safety rules are expensive and contested.** Roughing the passer, the defenseless player, the 2018 helmet rule, the horse-collar and hip-drop bans are mostly 15-yard personal fouls with an automatic first down; from 2026, repeat violations of five listed rules bring a suspension.
- **Enforce it yourself:** accept or decline, which spot, how far (half the distance near a goal line), what down. The automatic first down, not the yardage, is what makes a five-yard defensive foul worth a point.

Connections

Builds on: Coverage Fundamentals (press and the 1978 five-yard rule); Pass Protection (why linemen hold); Run-Pass Options (the lineman's one-yard limit); Dropback Concepts (rub routes); Zone Running (cut blocks); and The Pre-Snap Phase (live-ball fouls and offside).

Sets up: Officiating, Replay, and the Rules of the Ball (who throws which flag, replay, catches, fumbles and grounding); Red Zone, Goal Line, Two-Point Plays, and Short Yardage (the tush push, and half-the-distance football at the goal line); Clock and Game Management (untimed downs and penalties in the two-minute drill); and the history chapters The 1978 Liberation and Dynasties and Counterpunches, on how rule changes reshaped offense. **Case study:** The Eagles: Trenches, RPOs, and the Tush Push. **Data:** Expected Points and Success Rate (penalty snaps in EPA). **Reference:** the penalty quick-reference table in Appendix E.

Go deeper

- The NFL's *Official Playing Rules* (Rules 8, 12 and 14 cover this chapter) and its video rulebook, with a short clip for each foul, both at NFL Football Operations: operations.nfl.com.
- Ben Austro's *Football Zebras* site: rule changes, officiating mechanics and enforcement puzzles, explained by people who study officials.
- Mike Pereira and Dean Blandino, former NFL heads of officiating, on rules segments for FOX and elsewhere, for how officials think about judgment calls.
- For the history, *The Games That Changed the Game* by Ron Jaworski (2010), on how rules and schemes chased each other, and the Pro Football Hall of Fame's year-by-year history pages.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

Decline, almost always. If the defense **accepts**, the incompletion is wiped out and the hold is enforced from the previous spot: ten yards back to the offense's own 30, and the down is replayed, so it's **third-and-18**. If it **declines**, the play stands: an incompletion on third down makes it **fourth-and-8** at the 40, and the offense will almost certainly punt.

A third-and-18 isn't hopeless: offenses converted third-and-16 to third-and-20 about 10% of the time in 2021–2025. A punt gives the offense no chance at all. So the defense declines and takes the ball after the punt. The exceptions are the situations where fourth down isn't a punt down. Near midfield late in a game, or against a team that goes for it on fourth-and-8, a defense might accept and make the offense try again from ten yards further back.

Note the holding price here: it never got enforced. Declining is the defense saying the play itself already punished the offense more than the penalty would.

Answer 2.

A Hail Mary into the end zone. With four seconds left, there is time for one play, and only a touchdown wins. A completion short of the goal line ends the game as soon as the receiver is tackled. That is one reason to throw into the end zone. Here is the other, and it comes from this chapter: **a half can't end on an accepted defensive foul**. If a defender interferes in the end zone, the offense gets the ball on the **1-yard line** with an **untimed down**, a far better chance than a 42-yard heave.

That's why the receivers converge on one spot and fight for position, and why defensive backs are coached to go for the ball (jump and bat it down) rather than for the receiver. Officials are reluctant to call interference in a crowd where everyone is jostling for a jump ball, but a defender who grabs or tackles a receiver before the ball arrives gives the offense its best chance of the day. The eight deep defenders are there to make sure nobody catches it *and* that nobody has to foul to prevent it.

Answer 3.

A rub (pick) concept out of the bunch. Against press man, with three defenders lined up a yard off three receivers standing close together, the receivers' release paths will cross the defenders' paths almost at once. A classic call is one receiver releasing inside on a slant or in-breaking route, another breaking out to the flat, and the third pushing vertically to clear the area; one of the defenders chasing his man has to fight through a teammate's release.

Legal if the contact happens within a yard of the line. Because the defenders are pressed at one yard, the crossing happens right at the line, inside the one-yard strip where pass interference can't occur. If a receiver ran three yards and then stepped into a defender's path, it would be offensive pass interference, ten yards.

What the defense could have done: not press all three. Against bunches, defenses usually **align at different depths** (one defender pressed, the others four or five yards off), so nobody can be picked within the first yard; or they **switch/banjo**, trading receivers by agreement so no defender chases through the traffic; or they play **zone**, where nobody is chasing a man at all. Lining up pressed on a tight bunch is inviting the rub.